

UNDER THREAT: RESPONSES TO AND THE CONSEQUENCES OF THREATS TO INDIVIDUALS' IDENTITIES

JENNIFER LOUISE PETRIGLIERI
Harvard University

I review and reconceptualize identity threat, defining it as an experience appraised as indicating potential harm to the value, meanings, or enactment of an identity. I also develop a theoretical model and propositions that generate insights into how individuals respond to identity threats originating from a range of sources. I use this theory to explore individual and organizational consequences of different identity threat responses and their implications for research on identity dynamics within organizations.

Threats to identity are as ubiquitous as they are unsettling. When people feel that their identity is threatened, they respond in ways that give rise to a host of individual, group, and organizational effects. Identity threats can lead to decreased individual performance (Steele, 1997), decreased self-esteem (Taylor & Brown, 1988), and decreased desire to take on leadership positions (Davies, Spencer, & Steele, 2005); deliberate attempts to block organizational change efforts (Nag, Corley, & Gioia, 2007); non-conformance with company rules (Elsbach, 2003); entrenchment of identity conflicts between workgroups (Fiol, Pratt, & O'Connor, 2009); voluntary employee turnover (Trevor & Nyberg, 2008); stigmatization (Ashforth & Kreiner, 1999); and sex-based harassment (Berdahl, 2007).

The importance of understanding identity threat and how individuals respond to it is clear to scholars from a broad range of specializations, and both conceptual work and empirical work in this area have burgeoned in recent years. Much as in other areas of identity scholarship, however, research on identity threat is still at the stage of a "loosely organized" body of work (Ashforth, Harrison, & Corley, 2008; Pratt, Rockmann, & Kaufmann, 2006; Sveningsson &

Alvesson, 2003). Rather than converging toward a consensual view, existing research has produced multiple perspectives on the concept that partially, but not entirely, overlap.

At the most fundamental level, there is a lack of agreement regarding what, exactly, identity threat is. This conceptual discord centers on three distinct yet ultimately related theoretical points of contention. The first concerns the temporal aspect of identity threat (e.g., Breakwell, 1983; Kreiner & Sheep, 2009). Do threats harm identity in the present (Breakwell, 1983; Kreiner & Sheep, 2009), or do they warn of potential harm to identity in the future (e.g., Lazarus & Folkman, 1984; Major & O'Brien, 2005)? The second concerns the question of whether specific experiences, such as when an individual devalues another's identity, can be objectively classified as identity threats (Branscombe, Ellemers, Spears, & Doosje, 1999). Do some experiences always pose a threat to identity, or does identity threat result from an individual's subjective appraisal of an experience (Elsbach, 2003)? The final point of contention concerns the manner in which threat affects an individual's identities. The most extensively researched perspective views threat's impact to be a devaluation of the individual's identity—that is, the self-worth derived from holding the threatened identity is reduced (e.g., Ashforth, Kreiner, Clark, & Fugate, 2007; Fine, 1996; Roberts, 2005; Tajfel & Turner, 1979). A second research stream regards threat's effect as rendering the meanings associated with an identity unsustainable—that is, the threatened identity no longer says what it used to about the individual who holds it (e.g., An-

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teby, 2008; Burke, 1991; Elsass & Ralston, 1989). And yet a third perspective concerns threat's impact on the enactment of identity—that is, the threatened identity can no longer be expressed as freely or consistently as it used to be (e.g., Cooke & Rousseau, 1984; Kreiner, Hollensbe, & Sheep, 2006b; Maitlis, 2009; Shepherd & Haynie, 2009). In short, varied views exist on the temporality and nature of identity threat and its effects on an individual's identities.

The research mentioned above has focused on and significantly advanced our understanding of the experiences that cause identity threat, as well as the threat's consequences for the individual. Scant attention has been paid, however, to what happens in between an identity-threatening experience and its consequences—that is, to the process by which individuals recognize an experience as identity threatening, assess its impact, and decide how to respond to it. Understanding and clearly describing this process does not just shed light on a current theoretical black box. It is critical to progress on two important and timely research questions.

The first question concerns the consequences of identity threat and people's responses to it. Extant research has focused heavily on identity threats as negative forces with problematic consequences (e.g., Blanz, Mummendey, Mielke, & Klink, 1998; Breakwell, 1986). As a result, responses to identity threats have been framed in terms of attempts to minimize harm. Scholars, however, have recently asked, "How can positive outcomes emerge from identity conflict, tension, and threat?" (Roberts, Dutton, & Bednar, 2009: 503). One key contribution of this article is to propose a model of identity threat that accounts for a broad range of individual responses and consequences and that provides a platform to systematically address this question. Understanding the conditions under which identity threat can trigger responses that lead to either problematic or beneficial consequences has the potential to broaden the predominant negative focus in the field as well as to chart a course for an expanded and revitalized research agenda.

The second question concerns the level of mutability of individuals' identities. Foundational scholarship in this area emphasized that a key property of identities was their enduring nature (e.g., James, 1957/1890; Strauss, 1977). More recently, however, scholars have begun examining the many ways in which identities do

change, and a growing body of theoretical and empirical work on identity within organization studies has focused on identity's dynamism (e.g., Ashforth, 2001; Ibarra, 1999; Markus & Wurf, 1987). In short, to maintain a sense of continuity over time and yet adapt to shifting personal and social conditions, individuals need to balance their need to preserve identity stability with their need to sustain identity dynamism. The theoretical model in this article takes both sides of this polarity into account in examining the role of identity threat in the making, holding, undoing, and revising of individual identities. In accounting for a broad range of individual responses, the model presented here elucidates when and how identity threat is likely to provoke protection of the status quo and when it potentially opens up opportunities for change and growth.

Being clear about how we conceptualize identity threat, along with having a broader understanding of the process by which individuals respond to it, is especially important for understanding how individual identity dynamics impact organizations, and vice versa. Because people spend the majority of their lives working for, interacting with, and/or associating with organizations, such entities become crucial in determining a person's identity (Elsbach, 1999; Gini, 2001; Pratt, 1998). Concurrently, when interacting within and between organizations, individuals are likely to encounter a range of identity threats (Fine, 1996; Roberts, 2005; Rothbard, 2001). How they respond to these has consequences not only for them but also for the organizations they belong to. In exploring both individual and organizational consequences of possible responses to identity threat, this article also contributes to scholarship on individual identity and informs the management literature concerned with a range of organizational phenomena, such as organizational commitment (Johnson & Chang, 2006), group relations (Glynn, 2000), and organizational change (Nag et al., 2007).

The article is divided into four sections. In the first section I draw on extant literature to develop a definition of identity threat that takes into account its varied sources and effects and brings clarity to current theoretical points of contention. I argue that identity threat arises from an individual's subjective appraisal of an experience as indicating potential harm to one

of the individual's identities. The second section begins by describing the threat responses individuals use to minimize the likelihood of such harm. I classify these responses into two broad categories—those that target the source of the threat and those that target the threatened identity. I then develop a theoretical model that explains the conditions under which individuals pursue specific responses to identity threat. In the third section I apply the theoretical model to tease out the consequences of various identity threat responses for the individual and his or her organization. My model suggests that some types of threat response maintain the threat whereas others eliminate it. I argue that beneficial consequences only arise when responses eliminate the threat. In addition, I theorize that, in doing so, such responses open up the possibility for identity gain and growth. The article ends with a discussion that highlights the contributions of this theory to current identity scholarship and its potential to open up a research agenda that links identity threat to change and growth.

DEFINING IDENTITY THREAT

Understanding Identity

To understand identity threat it is first necessary to define identity. Because there is so much diversity in theoretical approaches to identity, the concept has multiple meanings. While reconciling these various approaches is beyond the scope of this article, I aim to address Pratt and Foreman's (2000) plea for authors to delineate clearly what they mean by the term *identity* in the context of their work.

First, this article is concerned with identities located in an individual—not those of a collective. To define identity at the individual level, I draw from and combine the two established theoretical perspectives on individual identity in organization studies: social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1986) and identity theory (Stryker, 1987; Stryker & Burke, 2000). These hold that an individual's identities are based on group membership and roles (referred to collectively here as *social identities*) and on unique characteristics and traits (referred to here as *personal identities*; Ashforth, 2001). Adding a further layer of specificity to social identities, I distinguish between those that are mostly as-

cribed or involuntary, such as gender or race, and those that are mostly achieved or voluntary, such as being a member of a sports team or holding a defined civic role (Deaux, 1991).

Individuals tend to value their identities, which therefore are the vehicles for sustaining their sense of self-worth (Gecas, 1982). The more positive the value of an identity, the more self-worth an individual draws from it, and vice versa. In addition to value, each identity of a person is accompanied by a conceptualization of what it means to be "X." For example, a chef may associate the meaning of "artist" with his or her professional identity and, hence, may regard him/herself as an artist by virtue of his or her profession (Fine, 1996). As socially embedded creatures, individuals negotiate their identities within social relationships and interactions that assign value to identities, define and shape their meanings, and ascribe (or deny) identities (Mead, 1934; Swann, 1987; White, 1992). Furthermore, because identities are shaped by social interactions, they require enactment in social settings to be sustained (Fine, 1996; Leifer, 1988).

Individuals hold multiple identities, and these are not all alike. One key way in which identities differ is in their level of importance to the individual. This property, referred to in identity theory as *identity salience*, describes how central an identity is to an individual's goals and core sense of self (Ashforth, 2001) and how likely it is to be invoked in a given situation (Stets & Burke, 2000). Individuals differ in the level of importance they place on a specific identity; thus, each individual's hierarchy of important identities is different.

Finally, identities are, to varying degrees, mutable and, thus, dynamic (Markus & Wurf, 1987). Much recent research has focused on the malleability of identity, which can take four forms: (1) altering the level of importance of an identity (Crocker & Major, 1989; Shamir, 1991); (2) changing the meanings associated with an identity (Newman, 1988; Pratt et al., 2006); (3) exiting an identity—that is, abandoning the identity and physically disengaging from any role or group associated with it (Ebaugh, 1988; Latack & Dozier, 1986); and (4) entering—that is, acquiring—a new identity (Bauer, Morrison, & Callister, 1998; Ibarra, 1999). A number of factors influence the malleability of an identity. One is the degree to which an identity is ascribed. Giving up a pro-

fessional identity may be hard, but letting go of a gender or racial identity is even harder, if possible at all (Deaux, 1991). Another is the degree to which an identity's meanings are socially negotiable and, thus, open for change (Billig & Tajfel, 1973; Ellemers, Spears, & Doosje, 2002). A third is the availability of alternative identities. Exiting a professional identity is easier for an individual when he or she has an alternative one to transition to (Ebaugh, 1988). Although identities can and do change, individuals are strongly motivated to maintain and enact their identities in their current state in order to achieve a sense of stability and continuity over time, as well as to maintain a high level of self-regard (Shamir, 1991).

Identity Threat

Unlike some concepts within the field of identity research (e.g., organizational identity; Albert & Whetten, 1985), there is no widely accepted and frequently used definition of identity threat in the literature. While some scholars have proposed broad definitions (e.g., Branscombe et al., 1999; Breakwell, 1986; Elsbach & Kramer, 1996; Kreiner & Sheep, 2009), the majority have preferred either to leave the concept undefined (e.g., Anteby, 2008; Ashforth et al., 2007; Dutton &

Dukerich, 1991) or to craft bespoke definitions that depend on the specific context under study (e.g., Elsbach, 2003; Major & O'Brien, 2005). Table 1 provides a sample of identity threat definitions drawn from work in management, social psychology, and stress research. A review and synthesis of the literature lead me to define individual-level identity threats as *experiences appraised as indicating potential harm to the value, meanings, or enactment of an identity*.

This definition, I argue, encompasses the diversity of existing scholarship on identity threat while sharpening its focus. First, it acknowledges the pivotal role of an individual's appraisal of various experiences as possible identity threats. Second, it clarifies identity threat's unique feature of arising from present cues of future harm. Third, it incorporates work on identity threat's effect on the value, meanings, and enactment of identity that has, so far, mostly progressed in parallel. I address each of these three aspects below.

The appraisal of threat. Appraisal is a two-part process by which people evaluate the significance of an experience for their well-being (primary appraisal) and determine what to do in response to it (secondary appraisal; Smith, 1991). The appraisal process is an integral part of models of psychological stress and coping

TABLE 1
Definitions of Identity Threat

Source	Definition
Breakwell (1983: 13)	"Any thought, feeling, action, or experience that challenges the individual's personal or social identity is a threat."
Liebkind (1983: 191)	"The closer a person comes to having to construe himself in a new and alien manner (compared with the present identity system), the more likely he is to feel threatened."
Lazarus & Folkman (1984: 21)	"Psychological stress is a relationship between the person and the environment that is appraised by the person as taxing or exceeding his or her resources and endangering his or her well-being."
Breakwell (1986: 46)	"A threat to identity occurs when the process of identity, assimilation-accommodation, and evaluation are, for some reason, unable to comply with the principles of continuity, distinctiveness, and self-esteem, which habitually guide their operation."
Branscombe, Ellemers, Spears, & Doosje (1999: 36)	There are four classes of identity threat: "(1) being categorized against one's will, (2) group distinctiveness is prevented or undermined, (3) the group's value is undermined, (4) one's position within the group is undermined."
Elsbach (2003: 632)	"An instance in which a participant perceived that the nonterritorial workspace impeded his or her ability to affirm or display an aspect of identity."
Major & O'Brien (2005: 402)	"Stigma-induced identity threat results when an individual appraises the demands imposed by a stigma-relevant stressor as potentially harmful to his or her social identity and as exceeding his or her resources to cope with those demands."
Pratt, Rockmann, & Kaufmann (2006: 235)	"Work-identity integrity violations: an experienced mismatch between what physicians did and who they were."
Kreiner & Sheep (2009: 32)	"Individuals face identity threats when their sense of self is called into question."

(Lazarus, 1966; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984), and it directly applies to identity threats, which are a type of stressor.

In primary appraisal, as it relates to identity, an individual assesses what significance an experience has for his or her identity. Thus, primary appraisal is based on an evaluation of both the experience and the individual's identity. Psychological stress and coping models describe five possible primary appraisals of an experience, here made specific to the realm of identity: (1) it is irrelevant for identity, (2) it preserves or benefits identity (benign/positive), (3) it holds potential for identity gain/growth (challenge), (4) it harms identity (harm/loss), and (5) it holds potential for harm to identity (threat; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Given this article's focus, from here on I focus solely on the last type of possible appraisal—that is, that of threat. What sets an experience apart as identity threatening is that it is appraised as indicating potential harm to an identity, and, thus, it is a present cue of future harm. Experiences appraised as identity threatening may also be appraised as harming the identity in the present (Major & O'Brien, 2005). A harm/loss appraisal alone, however, is not sufficient to threaten identity.

Consider the following example. A middle manager who aspires to a senior executive position is standing in line to buy a coffee shortly after her return to work from maternity leave. While waiting, she overhears two strangers denigrating working mothers and questioning their career commitment. On a different occasion the woman overhears her boss and a close colleague having a similar conversation. While in both situations the woman may feel that her professional identity is devalued in the moment (a harm/loss appraisal), in the second situation she is more likely to project future negative consequences, such as being passed over for promotion, being generally devalued over time, and being less able to claim a potential senior executive identity, her current manager identity, or her mother identity at work. While she may appraise both experiences as harmful to her identity, she is much more likely to appraise the latter as an identity threat.

Because primary appraisal is based on evaluations of both the experience and the individual's identity, people may appraise an experience differently. The impending bankruptcy of an employing organization may be appraised as

threatening to a person who is entrenched in the organization and could not imagine working elsewhere, but it may not be for another who is on the verge of transitioning to another organization. Even under more comparable conditions, two individuals may vary in how they appraise an experience. Many variables related to both the person and the situation may influence this, such as a person's tendency to self-monitor (Snyder & Gangestad, 1986) or the level of ambiguity of a situation (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Here I highlight two—identity importance and experience recurrence—which I draw on because of their links to identity threat in the existing literature.

Individuals are more likely to attend to identity-related information when it pertains to an identity they deem important (Stryker & Serpe, 1994); thus, they are more likely to appraise an experience as identity threatening when it relates to an important identity. Consider two Catholics—one who identifies strongly with and values his or her religious identity and another who does not. A work assignment that relocates both to a country that forbids the practice of their religion—and, as such, enactment of their Catholic identity for the duration of their assignment—is more likely to be appraised as threatening by the first than the second.

The more an individual is exposed to an experience (i.e., the more recurrent it is), the more likely he or she is to perceive it as identity threatening. This is because it will be salient and difficult to rationalize as an anomaly (Burke, 1991). Think of a manager who claims the identity of being a fair professional and strongly believes that she assesses subordinates' contribution independently of other factors. If the manager hears that one member of her team is looking for another job because of feeling disenfranchised by the manager's unequal treatment of people from different cultures, the manager may not register such one-off information or may shrug it off as an anomaly. If, however, the manager hears that several people have similar views about her treatment of colleagues and subordinates, the manager may appraise her identity as a fair manager to be under threat—that is, unless things change, she will be less able to claim that identity in the future.

Anticipated identity harm. A review of existing research reveals that appraisals of identity threat can be based on three distinct forms of

potential harm: (1) devaluing an identity in the future, (2) making the association between an identity and its meanings unsustainable in the future, and (3) limiting or preventing an identity's future enactment. For clarity, I present these three forms of potential harm separately here. In practice, however, an experience may be appraised as posing concurrent multiple indications of potential harm to an individual's identity.

Value. People tend to positively value their identities (Baumeister, 1998; Gecas, 1982; Hogg & Terry, 2000), and prior research has primarily focused on threat as an identity devaluation (Dutton, Roberts, & Bednar, 2010). Such threats generally stem from intergroup differences and the tendency of people to devalue members of outgroups (Tajfel & Turner, 1979). For example, societal prejudices against certain stigmatized identities, such as being a prostitute (Ashforth & Kreiner, 1999) or a member of a specific race (Roberts, 2005), mean that individuals who hold these identities are persistently devalued by others. Equally, people may consistently devalue others who originate from groups that hold oppositional identities—for example, members of a rival nation or workgroup (Fiol et al., 2009; Tajfel & Turner, 1979). As mentioned above, however, not all identity devaluations may be appraised as identity threatening. Some may simply provoke a harm/loss appraisal. Only those suggesting that the identity devaluation may be ongoing and extend into the future, as prejudices and intergroup conflicts usually do, will be appraised as identity threatening.

Meanings. Each of a person's identities is accompanied by a conceptualization of what it means to be "X"; for example, a blacksmith may associate the meanings of "independence" and "skill" with his or her professional identity and make those meanings part of how he or she views him/herself (Anteby, 2008). Identity meanings are threatened when an experience is appraised to suggest that the identity will not be associated with those meanings in the future. Individuals can themselves threaten one of their identity's meanings if they act in a way that is inconsistent with them. Their actions put a wedge between the identity and its current meanings by indicating that their association is not justified and, hence, will be difficult to sustain in the future. For example, blue collar workers who associate the meaning of "craftsmen" with their professional identity and see

themselves as such can threaten this association by taking jobs involving routinized work tasks that are not consistent with the creativity and improvisation involved in craftsmanship (Newman, 1988). The state of development of an identity can also be appraised as indicating that the association between an identity and its meanings will not be sustainable in the future (Hall, 2002). Thus, in career plateauing, the meaning of progress that individuals associate with their professional identity is threatened by the stagnant nature of their career (Elsass & Ralston, 1989).

Enactment. The third reason to appraise an experience as identity threatening is when it implies that the enactment of an identity will be limited or prevented in the future. The strongest such situation occurs when an individual appraises that he or she may, at some point, no longer be able to enact an identity. This can be triggered by an event, such as a chronic illness (Breakwell, 1983) or the death of a spouse (Neimeyer, Prigerson, & Davis, 2002), or by other people, such as when work colleagues reject each other's recounted identity narratives (e.g., of being an "honest cop"; Van Maanen, 1997). Threats that indicate future limits on the enactment of an identity often result from the competing demands of multiple identities. This can occur, for example, when the demands of a professional identity encroach on the expression of family role identities (Rothbard, 2001) or, more generally, when people overemphasize social identities at the expense of personal identities, or vice versa (Brewer, 1991; Kreiner et al., 2006b).

Forms and sources of threat. A vast array of experiences can be appraised as indicating potential identity harm—for example, events (e.g., the implementation of nonterritorial office space that limits the expression of personal identities at work; Elsbach, 2003), interactions (e.g., feedback that denies a claim to a cherished identity; Fine, 1996), and personal actions (e.g., conducting work that contradicts the meanings associated with one's professional identity; Anteby, 2008). Because an objective experience, such as when a person devalues another's identity (Branscombe et al., 1999), cannot be deemed identity threatening until an individual appraises it as such, providing a fine taxonomy of these experiences would be of limited theoretical use. What is valuable, however, is considering the sources of these experiences, because

these help to predict how a person will respond to threat. In short, identity threats can originate from the individual, others, or the material world.

Threats originating from individuals themselves stem either from identity conflicts or from carrying out an identity-threatening action. Identity conflicts—that is, conflicts between “the values, beliefs, norms and demands inherent in [the] identities” (Ashforth & Mael, 1989: 29)—are not necessarily threatening; they only become so when they are seen as indicating that it is not possible to sustain both identities in their current form in the future (e.g., Kreiner, Hollensbe, & Sheep, 2006a; Rothbard, 2001). As previously described, an individual’s actions can be threatening if they are inconsistent with the meanings that the individual associates with a specific identity (Anteby, 2008; Newman, 1988).

An individual’s social world is the second source of identity threat. Threats from other individuals generally take the form of interpersonal interactions (Fine, 1996; Van Maanen, 1997). At the group level, threats that originate with a person’s ingroup usually are interactions that question the individual’s allegiance to the group and, hence, limit his or her ability to be a group member in the future; this threat is particularly common in organizations with strong or demanding identities (Albert & Whetten, 1985). In contrast, threats that originate with an outgroup are more likely to be judgments devaluing the worth of a specific social identity, as is common in situations of intergroup conflict (Fiol et al., 2009; Tajfel & Turner, 1986). At the most macro level, threats may originate from beliefs and prejudices held by a society as a whole.

The final possible source of threat is the material world, such as a disabling car accident that cuts short a promising career (Maitlis, 2009). Threats from the material world involve external events, are generally traumatic, occur randomly, and are unique as threat sources in that they are independent of specific individuals or groups (Neimeyer et al., 2002; Pals & McAdams, 2004).

Identity Threat Coping Responses

Appraising an experience as threatening drives an individual to pursue an anticipatory coping response in an effort to negate the potential harm (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Anticipa-

tory coping responses, as they relate to identity threat, are cognitive and behavioral efforts that aim to decrease the likelihood or severity of potential identity harm (Major & O’Brien, 2005). I group the various anticipatory coping responses (from here on termed *threat responses* for simplicity), detailed in the assorted identity threat literature, into two categories based on their target. Responses in the first category target the source of the threat in order to protect the threatened identity; responses in the second category target the threatened identity in order to make it less of an object for potential harm. I refer to the first category as *identity-protection responses* and the second as *identity-restructuring responses*.

Identity-protection responses. These are directed toward the source of the threat and involve no change to the individual’s threatened identity. This category encompasses three types of response: (1) derogation, (2) concealment, and (3) positive-distinctiveness.

Derogation of the source of the threat protects an individual’s threatened identity by discrediting the source’s validity, thus rendering irrelevant any potential harm. This identity-protection response, sometimes called “condemn[ing] the condemners” (Sykes & Matza, 1957), is frequently observed in competitive situations between groups (Branscombe & Wann, 1994; Fiol et al., 2009) and has been proposed as the mechanism underlying sex-based harassment (Berdahl, 2007; Maass, Cadinu, Guarnieri, & Grasselli, 2003). Derogation enables an individual to cope with the identity threat’s potential negative effects by reducing their severity; it does not, however, reduce their likelihood.

Individuals may alternatively cope with threat by concealing an identity that they appraise to be threatened in a particular context so as to appear to be someone who possesses a nonthreatened identity (Tajfel, 1978). This response, which I term *concealment*, attempts to decrease the likelihood of potential identity harm. An example of this is when homosexuals refrain from discussing their personal life at work in order to appear heterosexual and, thus, avoid being the target of encounters that could cause identity harm (Creed & Scully, 2000; Frable, 1997). When the threatened identity is highly visible (e.g., race or gender), total concealment is not possible, and individuals may seek instead to downplay or suppress character-

istics or behaviors associated with the threatened identity in an attempt to make it less salient to others (Roberts, 2005).

In the final identity-protection response individuals present identity-enhancing information in an attempt to change the attitudes of the individuals or groups who are the source of the threat and make it less likely that they will act in ways that brings harm to the identity in the future. This response, which Ellemers et al. (2002) term *positive-distinctiveness* because of individuals' efforts to distinguish their threatened identity in a positive rather than negative way, includes actively educating others about the value of the threatened identity (Creed & Scully, 2000) and displaying pride in the identity by incorporating it into other aspects of the self (Ely, 1995). Like the concealment response, the positive-distinctiveness response aims to reduce the likelihood of potential identity harm.

Identity-restructuring responses. In contrast to those that involve identity protection, identity-restructuring responses are directed toward changing an aspect of the threatened identity. This category encompasses three types of response: (1) changing the importance of the threatened identity (importance change), (2) changing the meanings associated with the threatened identity (meaning change), and (3) abandoning the identity and physically disengaging from any role or group associated with the identity (identity exit).

The more important an identity is to the individual, the more self-defining it is and, hence, the greater the psychological distress the person feels when it is threatened (Ellemers et al., 2002; Swann, 1987). Decreasing the importance of an identity decreases its motivational significance and, thus, the severity of the threat's potential harm. For example, college students who experience threat to the value of their racial identity claim it to be a much less important identity at the end of their first year as compared to when they started college (Crocker & Major, 1989).

The second identity-restructuring response involves changing the meanings that the individual associates with the threatened identity (Burke, 2006; Deaux, 1991). This response is only relevant when an identity threat indicates that the association between an identity and its current meanings is unsustainable in the future. In a study of medical specialists in training, sur-

gery interns who initially saw surgeons as enactors of "dramatic change in disease" regularly found that identity threatened by having to do large amounts of menial patient care during their training. In response, they revised the meaning of the "surgeon" identity to being "the most complete doctors in the hospital" (Pratt et al., 2006: 247). This revised version of what being a surgeon meant accounted for both their "dramatic" work in the operating theater and the "menial" activities of routine rounds and write-ups, which eliminated the threat embedded in engaging in the latter.

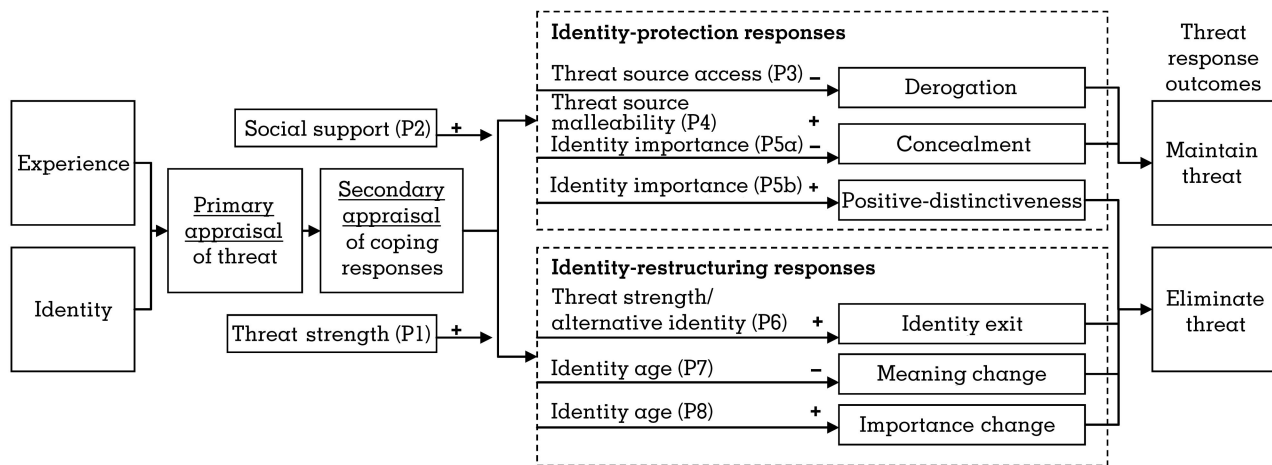
The final response within the identity-restructuring category is identity exit, which eliminates the threat target and, thus, the likelihood of potential harm. This occurs when an individual abandons the threatened identity and physically disengages from any role or social groups associated with it (Ashforth, 2001; Ebaugh, 1988). For instance, decrees from the Second Vatican Council led to a redefinition of what it meant to be a nun, a change that severely threatened the identities of many nuns and led to an unprecedented number leaving their calling (Ebaugh, 1988). It should be noted that this response is potentially very costly to the individual (Thoits, 1983) and is also often coupled with the transition to and acquisition of a new identity—two points that I will return to later.

A PREDICTIVE MODEL OF IDENTITY THREAT RESPONSES

Working from the definition of identity threat presented above, I now develop a theoretical model, depicted in Figure 1, of how individuals respond to identity threats. The model includes a series of propositions that explain the conditions under which individuals pursue specific responses to identity threat; these are labeled P1 to P10 in the figure.

As previously described, appraising an experience as identity threatening via the primary appraisal process drives an individual to pursue a threat response with the aim of decreasing the likelihood or severity of the potential identity harm. A secondary appraisal process determines which specific threat response will be pursued. During this secondary appraisal, individuals first assess which threat response is most likely to decrease the likelihood or severity of potential harm (Smith & Kirby, 2001). Conse-

FIGURE 1
Theoretical Model of Identity Threat Process and Responses



quently, secondary appraisal is based on an evaluation of the range of possible coping responses in addition to the experience and the threatened identity. I first deal with conditions that predict which category the response will belong to and then explore conditions that influence the adoption of specific responses within each category.

Conditions Influencing the Category of Threat Response

As previously described, individuals are strongly motivated to maintain and enact their identities in their current state in order to both achieve a sense of stability and continuity over time and maintain a high level of self-regard (Shamir, 1991). Consequently, the default response to an identity threat will be one of the identity-protection ones that target the threat source without involving any changes to the threatened identity (Swann, 1990). Although the drive for stability is strong, identities can and do change in response to identity threat. The first condition that affects this involves what I refer to as *strong threats*. A strong threat occurs either when the potential future harm to identity is great or when the threatening experience is encountered frequently (Burke, 1991). In these situations, responses that target the threat's source are likely to be ineffective given the scale of the threat, so some form of identity-restructuring response is necessary to decrease the severity or likelihood of future identity harm. Thus, I sug-

gest the following general relationship between the strength of the threat and the category of response triggered.

Proposition 1: The stronger the identity threat (in terms of magnitude and/or frequency), the more likely individuals will pursue an identity-restructuring response.

In my initial conceptualization of identity, I suggested that the meanings and value associated with an identity are shaped by social interactions and relationships. It follows that an individual's social environment needs to be considered to predict his or her response to an identity threat.

Social relationships not only shape an individual's identities; they can also lend social support to and sustain them (Schweder & Miller, 1985). By doing so, social support for a threatened identity makes an identity-protection response more likely. This is particularly evident when threat relates to an appraisal of potential harm to the value of an identity. Research on socially stigmatized occupations classified as "dirty work" (e.g., garbage collectors, morticians, prison guards, etc.; Hughes, 1951) illustrates this link. For individuals doing such work, the social support stemming from deliberate "social buffering" (i.e., extensive socialization with other "dirty workers") partially insulates them from the chronic identity threats they encounter and also provides a constant source of identity affirmation (Ashforth et al., 2007). The

result is a high tendency of such individuals to respond to identity threats with identity-protection responses. Thus, the positive relationship between threat strength and identity-restructuring response can be moderated by social support.

Proposition 2: The more social support available for a threatened identity, the more likely individuals will pursue an identity-protection response.

This suggests that even when an identity threat is strong, and Proposition 1 would predict an identity-restructuring response, an identity-protection response may be triggered if the individual has a significant level of social support for the threatened identity. These two conditions indicate which category a threat response will belong to. Below I examine conditions that influence the pursuit of responses within the two categories.

Conditions Influencing the Adoption of Specific Identity-Protection Responses

The three identity-protection responses (derogation, concealment, and positive-distinctiveness) protect threatened identities through actions that target the people who are the source of the threatening experience. Derogation involves condemning the views of these people and does not necessarily require any direct interaction with them (Sykes & Matza, 1957). In contrast, concealment and positive-distinctiveness both involve significant interaction with the people who are the source of the threatening experience. Concealment involves hiding or downplaying the threatened identity in front of those who threaten it (Prokos & Padavic, 2002), while positive-distinctiveness involves presenting positive meanings associated with the threatened identity in an effort to educate and change the views of those who threaten the identity (Roberts, 2005). Given the requirement for interaction in the cases of concealment and positive-distinctiveness, it follows that should a threat originate from people with whom an individual cannot interact, the only available response is derogation.

Proposition 3: Among identity threats that provoke identity-protection responses, individuals are likely to pursue a derogation response when they cannot interact with the people who are the source of the threat.

sue a derogation response when they cannot interact with the people who are the source of the threat.

A derogation response can be triggered in tandem with either a concealment response or a positive-distinctiveness response. For example, a woman might simultaneously derogate male coworkers who denigrate women and respond with concealment tactics to downplay her own gender identity (Prokos & Padavic, 2002). The concealment and positive-distinctiveness responses are, however, mutually exclusive. Positive-distinctiveness requires considerable cognitive and emotional effort, and, thus, individuals are unlikely to use it if they feel that they will not be able to change others' perceptions of their identity (Cain, 1991; Major, Quinton, McCoy, & Schmader, 2000). To illustrate, female lawyers working in heavily male-dominated firms commonly use the concealment identity-protection response to downplay their gender identity and, hence, decrease associated identity threat (Ely, 1995). In contrast, those working in firms with a greater gender balance more commonly use the positive-distinctiveness response in dealing with threat to their gender identity. This difference is presumably due to the perception that heavily male-dominated firms are not receptive to the presentation of alternative female identity conceptualizations and, therefore, investing in a positive-distinctiveness response is not worthwhile. A similar pattern has been shown among professionals who are homosexual; only those who perceive their organizations to be receptive to positive messages regarding their sexual orientation use positive-distinctiveness responses, whereas others use concealment responses (Chrobot-Mason, Button, & DiClementi, 2001). This suggests the following proposition.

Proposition 4: Among identity threats that provoke identity-protection responses, individuals will only pursue a positive-distinctiveness response if they believe it possible to change others' perceptions of their identity.

The importance of a threatened identity to an individual is another significant factor determining whether a concealment or a positive-distinctiveness response will be pursued in the face of an identity threat. The more important an

identity, the more central it is to an individual's goals, values, and sense of self and the more the individual is motivated to display rather than hide it (Branscombe & Ellemers, 1998; Griffith & Hebl, 2002). Consequently, when an individual perceives a threat to an important identity, he or she should be more likely to invest the effort in a positive-distinctiveness response, assuming he or she deems it possible, than when less important identities are threatened. Research supports this and also demonstrates that when less important identities are threatened, concealment is the more likely response (Ethier & Deaux, 1994; Thomas, 1993).

Proposition 5a: Among identity threats that provoke identity-protection responses, the less important the threatened identity, the more likely individuals will pursue a concealment response.

Proposition 5b: Among identity threats that provoke identity-protection responses, the more important the threatened identity, the more likely individuals will pursue a positive-distinctiveness response.

Conditions Influencing the Adoption of Specific Identity-Restructuring Responses

All three identity-restructuring responses alter aspects of the threatened identity. One key way they differ is in the extent of their impact on the threatened identity. Changing the importance of an identity (importance-change response) or its meaning (meaning-change response) alters, respectively, the individual's hierarchy of identity importance or the meanings that he or she associates with the threatened identity. This is in contrast to the identity-exit response, which, by disengaging from the threatened identity and any associated role or social group, involves an actual deletion of the identity. Identity exit requires that the person both psychologically disengage from his or her identity and physically disengage from the social relations and context that sustain it (Ebaugh, 1988), both of which can be difficult and involve periods of adjustment (Carter & Cook, 1995). This, together with the strong association between an individual's psychological well-being and the number of identities he or

she holds (Thoits, 1983), makes the identity-exit response very costly to the individual. As previously highlighted, the cost of the identity-exit response can be decreased if an alternative identity exists that the individual can transition to as a substitute for the identity being exited. Even so, the high cost of the identity-exit response suggests that it will only be pursued in the face of a strong threat.

A relationship between strength of identity threat and extent of identity restructuring has been suggested by others (Kreiner et al., 2006a; Pratt et al., 2006). Furthermore, research on organizations that focus on identity transformation (e.g., Alcoholics Anonymous, religious movements, weight-loss organizations, etc.) and use identity threat to spark identity change in their recruits demonstrates the relationship between the identity-exit response and the combination of the presence of a strong threat and the availability of a substitute identity (Rudy & Greil, 1987). In such organizations the more physical, social, and/or ideological encapsulation of the new recruit—which creates a strong threat to an existing identity—and the clearer the alternative identity, the stronger the likelihood the individual will exit the threatened identity (Bromley & Shupe, 1979). Divestiture organizational socialization tactics that aim to make recruits exit an established identity are also found to be more effective when recruits are subjected to repeated or strong threats and are presented with an alternative identity (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). This leads to the following proposition.

Proposition 6: Among identity threats that provoke identity-restructuring responses, an identity-exit response is more likely when there is a strong threat coupled with the provision of an alternative identity.

During the course of their professional and personal lives, all individuals experience multiple transitions to new identities (Glaser & Strauss, 1971; Levinson, 1978). Before entering a new identity, people commonly engage in a process of anticipatory socialization, in which they seek information about and associate a set of meanings with the new identity (Merton, 1957). The moment of entry into a new identity is typically marked by a period of "surprise" (Louis, 1980), during which the meanings that an indi-

vidual associated with the new identity during anticipatory socialization may be proven unrealistic and, thus, may be threatened as being unsustainable. People typically respond to such threats by changing the meanings that they associate with the new identity. This link between the meaning-change response and threat directed at a newly acquired identity is illustrated in research that investigates individuals entering a new professional identity (Ibarra, 1999; Louis, 1980; Pratt et al., 2006), and it has also been shown to be prevalent in transitions to new personal identities—for example, in people who are newly married (Burke, 2006).

Proposition 7: Among identity threats that provoke identity-restructuring responses, the meaning-change response is more likely when the threatened identity is newly acquired.

Although the meaning-change response is likely during transitions to new identities, it is costly as a threat response when the threatened identity is established (I use the term *established* to refer to an identity that is not new but long held). This is because the meanings an individual associates with a given identity are, at least in part, determined by social expectations (Gergen, 1985; White, 1992). Changing the meanings of an established identity can threaten an individual's legitimacy as a holder of the identity and the social relationships predicated on it (Ellemers et al., 2002). In contrast to the meaning-change response, the importance-change response aims to decrease the motivational significance of the threatened identity, thereby decreasing the potential harm that the threat could bring (Shamir, 1991). Consequently, this response is not accompanied by a potential threat to the legitimacy of an individual as a holder of that identity. As a result, when the threatened identity is established, the importance-change response will be less costly and more prevalent. For example, when two established identities—say, parent and professional—conflict because an individual is overinvested in one at the expense of the other—and the latter causes a threat to the former's enactment—the response commonly involves changing the importance of the identities in order to regain balance and diminish conflict (Brewer, 2003; Kreiner et al., 2006b).

Proposition 8: Among identity threats that provoke identity-restructuring responses, the importance-change response is more likely when the threatened identity is established.

THREAT RESPONSE OUTCOMES AND THEIR CONSEQUENCES

This section extends the theoretical model just presented by exploring the outcomes of threat responses and outlining the consequences of these outcomes for individuals and their organizations. There are two distinct outcomes of threat responses: the maintenance of threat or its elimination. To eliminate threat, a response must alter either the threatened identity or the views of the people who are the source of the threatening experience. This is because an appraisal of threat is based on an evaluation of the experience and the identity, so unless one of these things changes, the appraisal of threat is likely to be maintained. I expand on these outcomes and their consequences below; they are also summarized in Table 2.

Maintaining Threat

The responses of derogating a threat's source or concealing a threatened identity decrease the likelihood of identity harm and enable the individual to cope with the identity threat. They do not, however, change the individual's threatened identity, nor do they change the views of the threat's source; they therefore maintain the appraisal of threat. Because of this, the individual must continue to pursue a threat response in order to minimize potential identity harm—that is, the individual must sustain derogation or keep hiding. This leads to problematic consequences, illustrated below, for both the individual and the organization.

When individuals appraise one of their ascribed social identities as threatened in their workplace, they often choose to conceal it. This situation may stem from coworkers' prejudice toward ascribed identities, such as gender and/or race. It may also derive from the organization's identity. For example, the antihomosexual stance central to the organizational identity of many churches may threaten gay members (Creed, DeJordy, & Lok, 2010). By maintaining the threat, concealment has problematic conse-

TABLE 2
Individual and Organizational Consequences of Responses to Identity Threat

Threat Response	Individual Consequences	Organizational Consequences
Derogation	• Social isolation and reinforcement identity threat dynamic (Ashforth, Kreiner, Clark, & Fugate, 2007)	• Entrenched identity conflicts (Fiol, Pratt, & O'Connor, 2009)
Concealment	• Emotional distress, feelings of inauthenticity (Pachankis, 2007)	• Sex-based harassment (Berdahl, 2007)
Positive-distinctiveness	• Potentially more exposure to identity threat (Roberts, 2005)	• Increased intentions of employees to leave organization (Côté & Morgan, 2002)
Importance change	• Decreased conflict between work and personal identity (Day & Schoenrade, 1997) • Opportunity to invest in other identities and achieve optimal balance between identities (Kreiner, Hollensbe, & Sheep, 2009)	• Nonconformance to company rules (Elsbach, 2003) • Decrease in employees' intentions to leave organization (Côté & Morgan, 2002)
Meaning change	• Decreased organizational identification (Weisenfeld, 1997)	• Organizational socialization (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979) • Successful organizational change efforts (Dutton & Dukerich, 1991)
Identity deletion	• Construction of new professional identity (Pratt, Rockmann, & Kaufmann, 2006) • Identity growth (Kreiner & Sheep, 2009)	• Voluntary employee turnover (Lee & Mitchell, 1994) • Identity conversion (Greil & Rudy, 1984)

quences for the individual, who is likely to experience a secondary threat because of his or her limited ability to enact the threatened identity (Pachankis, 2007; Smart & Wegner, 1999). It also has problematic consequences for the organization, because individuals who feel they need to conceal an identity within an organization are more likely to leave it (Côté & Morgan, 2002; Morris & Feldman, 1996).

Threats that target an individual's professional role-based identity often stem from conflicts between groups within an organization (e.g., between musicians and symphony board members; Glynn, 2000). In these cases the most common identity-protection response is derogation, in which individuals disidentify with the opposing group (Elsbach, 1999; Elsbach & Bhat-tacharya, 2001; Pratt, 2000) and seek to distinguish themselves in opposing terms (Kelman, 2006; Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Derogation can contribute to the development of intractable identity conflicts (Fiol et al., 2009) that have problematic consequences for both individuals and their organizations, such as increased employee stress (Wedge, 1987), increased employee turnover (Humphreys & Brown, 2002), and decreased organizational creativity and flexibility (Williams & O'Reilly, 1998).

Eliminating Threat

The identity threat response of positive-distinctiveness and all of the identity-restructuring responses change either the individual's threatened identity or the views of the threat's source. In so doing they alter one of two key elements for the appraisal process and, thus, have the potential to eliminate the identity threat.

Revisiting the example of an individual whose racial or gender identity is threatened in the workplace, the alternative to concealment is revealing the threatened identity and pursuing a positive-distinctiveness response. Although this is costly for the individual in terms of cognitive and emotional effort (Major et al., 2000), it can eliminate the threat if it is successful in altering the views of others. This has the positive consequences of decreasing conflict between the individual's work role and other identities (Kahn, Wolfe, Quinn, & Snoek, 1964), and it benefits the organization by decreasing the intentions of people to leave (Côté & Morgan, 2002; Morris & Feldman, 1996).

Within organizations, threats that trigger identity-restructuring responses are particularly common during the crossing of boundaries, such

as when individuals enter a new organization or take on a new role. At these times individuals negotiate the meanings of their nascent identity vis-à-vis organizational identity, organizational expectations of their new role, their personal actions, and their existing identities, each of which presents the risk of encountering identity threat (Ashforth, 2001; Nicholson, 1984). In such situations the meaning-change response helps individuals to rapidly adapt and become effective in their new role or environment, which benefits both the individuals and their organization and leads to a rapid elimination of threat (Ibarra, 1999; Pratt et al., 2006; Van Maanen & Schein, 1979).

Organizations can harness the potential to eliminate identity threat by providing an impetus for individuals to engage in one of the identity-restructuring threat responses. Consider intractable identity conflicts between workgroups, previously described. Organizational leaders can significantly contribute to the resolution of such entrenched conflicts by diverting attention, and thus social support, away from group-based identities and onto a superordinate identity—for example, that of the organization (Fiol et al., 2009; Haslam, Eggins, & Reynolds, 2003). In this case, by providing an alternative set of meanings with which to identify, the organizational identity acts as an antidote to entrenched identity threat.

In addition to the direct beneficial consequences described, eliminating threat may also open the possibility for individuals to realize identity gain or growth. Identity gain is the acquisition of a new identity; identity growth is the fostering of a positive identity that is "competent, resilient, transcendent and holistically integrated" (Kreiner & Sheep, 2009: 24).

The burgeoning stream of literature investigating conflicts between work- and home-based role identities (Graves, Ohlott, & Ruderman, 2007; Greenhaus & Powell, 2006; Kreiner, Hollensbe, & Sheep, 2009) highlights a common situation in which an identity-restructuring response to threat can lead to identity growth. As previously discussed, changing the importance of the conflicting identities is a common response in such situations. Concurrent with eliminating threat, this response can bring an individual's identities closer to an optimum balance, which is "a state of being neither too distinct/independent nor too inclusive/depen-

dent in relation to a given social identity" (Kreiner et al., 2006b: 1033). Achieving an optimum balance between identities has been highlighted as one mechanism through which individuals achieve identity growth (Kreiner & Sheep, 2009: 24).

Turning to identity gain, the identity-deletion response may not simply result in identity loss but may be coupled with the transition to and acquisition of a new identity. Organizations with strong identities often harness this and systematically use identity threat to provoke identity transition in new recruits (Greil & Rudy, 1984). Considering the converse—individuals who voluntarily leave organizations—Ebaugh's (1988) study of role exit found that very few people left a role (i.e., disengaged from an identity) without considering alternatives they might transition to. For example, organizational change may threaten an individual's existing professional identity and trigger the person to take early retirement (identity-deletion response). This may, in turn, stimulate him or her and open the opportunity to pursue a long-held ideal identity, such as being an independent consultant in the not-for-profit sector.

While identity gain and growth are beneficial for an individual, they are not necessarily so for the individual's organization. For example, when individuals decrease the importance of a professional identity in response to threats originating from perceived procedural unfairness, they may experience identity growth in the form of attaining a more optimal balance between their work and home identities. For their organization, however, the result may be employees with lower levels of organizational identification and commitment (Weisenfeld, 1997). Equally, identity threats that lead individuals to exit an organization and transition to a new professional identity that represents identity gain for them can threaten the value of the identities of those remaining in the organization and lead to the snowball effect of clusters of organizational turnover (Krackhardt & Porter, 1986). A general observable pattern is that when an organization purposefully creates an identity threat—for example, in divestiture socialization tactics (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979) or deliberate attempts to convert the identities of members (Greil & Rudy, 1984)—the consequences of individuals' identity gain/growth are likely to be beneficial for the organization. Conversely,

when an identity threat stems from an organizational decision or practice overtly unrelated to individuals' identities—for example, an organizational restructuring program—the consequences of individuals' identity gain/growth are likely to be problematic for the organization.

DISCUSSION AND AVENUES FOR FUTURE RESEARCH

The concept of identity threat has held an important position in identity research and theorizing. While exploration of this concept is not new, the model proposed in this article aims to better define what identity threat is and to theorize about the various ways individuals respond to it, along with the consequences of these responses. The definition and model presented here advance identity scholarship by integrating multiple streams of extant research and offering an overarching theoretical process model with testable propositions that might inform future research. At a fundamental level the model generates insights into how and why individuals respond to identity threats originating from a range of sources. While these ideas can be applied to a wide variety of environments, the exploration of individual and organizational consequences of identity threat responses illustrates how they are particularly germane for understanding how individual identity dynamics impact organizations.

Although the presence of various forms of identity threat and the numerous responses to them have been noted (Branscombe et al., 1999; Breakwell, 1983), testable links between types of threat and responses have been lacking. My model presents a classification of identity threats and a set of factors that combine to specify conditions under which each of the multiple responses is most likely to be triggered. Moreover, the model suggests that the full spectrum of responses to identity threat is not always available to the individual. Extant identity threat research has primarily focused on the impact of and responses to singular identity threats (e.g., Ashforth et al., 2007; Elsbach, 2003), yet individuals may experience multiple threats simultaneously, particularly within organizations. For example, mergers between organizations headquartered in different countries may concurrently provoke threats to nationality-based ascribed social identities,

role-based professional identities, and group-based identities derived from legacy organizational identities. My model can inform research in this area by predicting the various responses to these multiple threats and the likely consequences for threatened individuals and their organizations. Further research is needed to understand whether individuals employ multiple responses simultaneously, attend to threats sequentially, or combine responses into a holistic strategy for dealing with various threats.

An important and potentially generative avenue for future research is to investigate the impact of time on an individual's response to identity threat. My model proposes that the strength of a threat, derived in part from how frequently a person encounters a potentially threatening experience, is key to determining whether an individual pursues an identity-protection or an identity-restructuring threat response. Future studies and conceptualization may clarify whether, for example, an individual who is exposed to ongoing threat will change his or her response to it over time. One possibility is that the individual may move from a response aimed at protecting the identity to one aimed at restructuring it, as the threat persists. Another is that the individual may habituate to ongoing threat, which will, in turn, make a protection response easier to sustain. The idea that threat responses could evolve over time is in line with scholarship viewing identity as undergoing periods of stability punctuated by periods of restructuring (Ibarra & Petriglieri, 2010; Yost & Strube, 1992).

Recognizing that beneficial consequences emerge from identity threat only when threat responses eliminate threat—that is, when they either change how the threat source sees the identity in question or change the individual's threatened identity—provides direction for an expanded and fruitful research agenda. An interesting question to pursue is whether and how it is possible to push people toward these responses. For example, in the case of the concealment versus positive-distinctiveness response, my theoretical model suggests that people are more likely to pursue the costly yet beneficial positive-distinctiveness response when they perceive the environment as receptive to positive characterizations of the threatened identity. This strengthens the view that organizational

identity, culture, and managerial practices have a pivotal role to play in dealing with identity threats. For example, by actively pursuing diversity training (Kulik, Pepper, Roberson, & Parker, 2007), employing a diverse workforce (Ely, 1994), and fostering cultures that dispel gossip (Kurland & Pelled, 2000), organizations may both reduce the incidences of identity threats and encourage the adoption of positive-distinctiveness responses should threat occur.

Particularly interesting for future research is further exploration of the suggestion that individuals' efforts to eliminate threat open up possibilities to realize identity gain and growth. Identity gain and growth are not automatic consequences of eliminating an identity threat. For individuals to reap these benefits, they must be able to reappraise an experience they formerly appraised as identity threatening and come to view it as holding the potential for identity growth or gain. Research on posttraumatic growth, which refers to "the positive psychological change experienced as a result of the struggle with highly challenging life circumstances" (Tedeschi & Calhoun, 2004: 1), suggests that the factors that may impact an individual's ability to reappraise a previously threatening situation may include the level of cognitive processing, or "ruminating" about the threatening experience (Tedeschi & Calhoun, 2004); the level of social support for acquisition of a new identity (Neimeyer, 2001); and the ability of the individual to disclose and discuss the troubling aspects of the identity-threatening situation (Ullrich & Lutgendorf, 2002). More work is needed to advance these strands and understand more clearly how individuals convert a threat response into an opportunity for identity gain and growth, as well as how they can be helped to do so more efficiently.

Highlighting that there are multiple possibilities for identity threat responses to result in beneficial consequences challenges the underlying assumption, found in much extant research, that the "best possible world" would be one devoid of identity threat. Just as high levels of person-organization fit confer the disadvantages of low levels of innovation and high resistance to change (Nemeth & Staw, 1989), low levels of identity threat may confer the disadvantages of ossification of identities. Clearly, some forms of identity threat—for example, those stemming from prejudice—should be eliminated from organizations.

Nonetheless, attempts to control and eliminate all forms of identity threat also remove opportunities for the beneficial consequences of identity change and growth. Of course, identity growth and gain can occur in the absence of identity threat—for example, when individuals develop a spiritual identity at work (Kreiner & Sheep, 2009). However, identity development is unlikely to progress linearly through an individual's lifetime toward more positive identities (Kegan, 1983; Levinson, 1978; Yost & Strube, 1992), and periodic challenges posed by identity threats may, in turn, spur new cycles of growth and integration.

The exploration of conditions under which identity threat results in problematic or favorable consequences sheds light on the question of how positive outcomes can emerge from identity conflict, tension, and threat (Roberts et al., 2009: 503). It also points to a previously unarticulated question: "To whom do the positive and negative consequences of identity threat accrue?" My perspective highlights that the consequences of identity threat do not necessarily point in the same direction for individuals and their organizations—that is, one may benefit and one may lose from certain threat responses. Therefore, future research needs to consider both individual and organizational levels of analysis when investigating the consequences of identity threats. In particular, it is important for scholars to recognize that identity-restructuring responses can point in opposite directions for the individual and the organization and not to assume that what is good for one is good for the other.

A recent perspective on organizations posits that individuals experience some but not all organizations as identity workspaces—settings conducive to pursuing identity consolidation and transition projects (Petriglieri & Petriglieri, 2010). An interesting research avenue would entail investigating how individuals respond to identity threat in organizations that they experience as identity workspaces as opposed to those that they do not. Another question that deserves attention is whether the number of members that experience an organization as an identity workspace is related to the organization's skillfulness in using identity threats.

The conceptualization and theoretical model of identity threat presented here also suggests a key role for identity threat in triggering identity

transitions. An identity transition is the movement between one identity, which is shed, and another, which is acquired (e.g., during a career transition; Ashforth, 2001; Ebaugh, 1988; Ibarra, 1999, 2003; Ibarra & Barbulescu, 2010). The number of people who contemplate a specific identity transition is always higher than the number who actually complete it (Ashforth, 2001; Ebaugh, 1988; Ibarra, 2007), and one significant gap in our understanding of this area is the identification of factors that motivate identity transition, especially in conditions outside of formal role passage (Ibarra, 2007). My proposition that under certain conditions identity threat can trigger identity deletion, a necessary part of the identity transition process, provides an answer, albeit partial, to this puzzle. Future research is needed to understand how prevalent the presence of identity threat is at the outset of identity transitions. Of particular use would be studies in which samples encompassed both individuals who simply considered an identity transition and those who actually made one. If such studies could clarify the factors differentiating the two groups, they could both test for the presence of identity threat in individuals who embark on identity transitions and highlight other factors necessary for or impeding such transitions.

This article has focused on threats to the identities of individuals. A worthwhile extension and application of the theory would be further exploration of the role of organizational identity in individuals' experience of identity threat within organizations. Because organizational members define themselves, at least partially, in terms of their organizational identity, events that threaten an organization's identity might also threaten the identities of individual members (e.g., Dutton & Dukerich, 1991; Elsbach & Kramer, 1996). Consider crises that threaten an organization's identity, such as the Gulf of Mexico oil spill that has brought and will likely bring more harm to BP's identity as an environmentally responsible organization. Organizational members who feel a direct threat as a result of the threat to their organization's identity may respond in various ways, such as altering the meanings they associate with their professional identity. In turn, if the threat occurs among senior executives who routinely function as sensegivers for the broader organization (Elsbach, 1994), this is likely to have other effects

on how they conceptualize the identity of their organization. Investigating the interplay among threats to organizational identity, threats to individual identity, and individual and organizational responses would further efforts to investigate the processes by which organizations and individuals jointly become rather than be (Ashforth, 1998; Ashforth, Rogers, & Corley, in press; Sveningsson & Alvesson, 2003).

Finally, a significant limitation to the advancement of identity threat research is the absence of a standard measurement scale for identity threat. Laboratory studies have tended to confirm the presence of identity threat via post-experimental manipulation checks showing that subjects realized they had been exposed to identity-threatening material (e.g., Davies et al., 2005). Field research has relied on individuals' mentioning the presence of identity threat in qualitative interview data (e.g., Elsbach, 2003). The development of a standard questionnaire scale—similar, for example, to the one developed by Mael and Ashforth to determine organizational identification (1992)—would enable researchers to test the presence of identity threat across a wide range of both experimental and field settings. The availability of a standardized measure can only help us to better understand the various circumstances in which threat arises and the responses that it triggers.

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Jennifer Louise Petriglieri (jpetriglieri@hbs.edu) is a postdoctoral fellow in organizational behavior at the Harvard Business School, Harvard University. She received her doctoral degree from INSEAD. Her current research explores identity dynamics in organizations and professions in crisis, the social function of business schools, and the dynamics of identity development in management education.